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5 Training Institutes:

Attaining a Higher Level of Functioning

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61.1 In its message dated 29 December 2015 to the Conference
**of the Continental Boards of Counsellors, the Universal House
of Justice stated that attaining a higher level of functioning is a
pressing concern of training institutes. This concern comes into
sharp focus when viewed in the context of the goals before the**

62 Bahá'í world during this Five Year Plan: to “seek to raise the number of clusters
where a program of growth has become
intensive to 5,000 by Rid .ván 2021”

1 and to add “several hun-

dred more”2 to some two hundred clusters that have already

2 advanced beyond the third milestone. As stated by the House of Justice:

61.2 The community’s efforts to fortify programs of growth in
**thousands of clusters and sustain their intensification will
place heavy demands on these agencies. Their focus, of
course, is the unfoldment of the three stages of the edu-
cational process they oversee and the strengthening of the**

62 process of learning associated with each, so that both the quality of the institute’s
activities and the capacity to extend

63 them to ever-growing numbers are constantly rising.

64 3

61.3 In the institutional meetings held across the world to pre-

62 pare for the beginning of the current Five Year Plan, the friends benefited from viewing what was happening in each cluster

from two perspectives. The first, engaging in three-monthly

cycles of activity through which the community grows, with

63 attention to teaching the Faith and conversation with those from the wider society, and, the second, the unfoldment of

the three educational imperatives overseen by the training

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65 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONinstitute. Regarding the latter, the House of Justice has stated

66 the following:

61.4 In this context, one speaks of three educational imperatives, each distinguished by its own methods and materials, each

claiming a share of resources, and each served by mecha-

62 nisms to systematize experience and to generate knowledge based on insights gained in the field. Quite naturally, then,

three discussions take shape around the implementation

63 of the program for the spiritual education of children, the junior youth spiritual empowerment program, and the main

64 sequence of courses.

65 4

61.5 To help the friends managing the operations of training

62 institutes to respond to current exigencies, this document shares some insights from the body of experience that has accrued

in the Bahá'í world about implementing the main sequence

63 of courses, the junior youth spiritual empowerment program,

64 and the program for the spiritual education of children. The document also addresses matters related to the institutional

capacity of training institutes. It is hoped that in each region

65 or country the friends responsible for the institute's endeavors will, taking their
particular circumstances and experience into

consideration, use these insights to further systematize their

66 efforts.

1 THE MAIN SEQUENCE OF COURSES

61.6 As is generally understood, the study of institute courses in a

given cluster often starts with only a small group of participants

who then begin to offer one or another of the acts of service

the courses recommend. For the process of growth to advance

meaningfully, the number of people studying institute courses

62 must continue to rise. The principal issues that lie at the heart of this objective include
raising the number and enhancing the

capacity of those serving as tutors, sustaining a steady flow of

63 participants through the sequence of courses, and coordinating the institute's efforts
through effective mechanisms.

1.1 Raising the Number and Enhancing

the Capacity of Tutors

61.7 Fundamental to strengthening the educational programs of

the training institute is a steadily increasing number of capable

62 tutors who, over time, are assisted to grow in effectiveness.

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Supplementary Material 1.1.1 The initial cadre of tutors

61.8 Institutes face a number of questions with regard to clusters

where a program of growth is nascent, among them: how to

meaningfully extend the reach of the study of institute courses

to each cluster, and how to ensure that "within a reasonable

period, some among those residing in a cluster are enabled to

serve as tutors."⁵

61.9 Local friends in clusters with new programs of growth

have initially relied on participating in the study of the courses

offered by experienced tutors in more advanced clusters nearby

or farther afield. They have also benefited from the services of

one or two carefully selected and prepared visiting tutors drawn

⁶² from the strong clusters who in some instances also serve as homefront pioneers for a short or long term. In either case, the

tutors involved are most effective when they appreciate that

⁶³ they are promoting a process with far-reaching implications for the spiritual and material life of a population. Besides

assisting the first batch of friends to arise and serve, through

the courses they offer the tutors help build a strong foundation

of understanding and experience on which the institute process

⁶⁴ is gradually erected.

^{61.10} Yet, it is not until some of the local friends begin serving

as tutors that the institute truly takes root in a cluster and the

number of those studying institute courses increases signifi-

cantly. The first steps in this regard may be to encourage a few

friends from among those who have studied the early courses

⁶² and gained some experience with the related activities to begin helping others study the courses. Visiting tutors may begin by

calling on these friends to help in leading discussions of sections

⁶³ of the materials and organizing the related practices. They might also delve with them deeper into challenging aspects of

the study and practice under way. In this manner, some local

friends are carefully enabled to start offering others at least the

first two courses of the sequence. An in-depth review of these

⁶⁴ courses, carried out together with a study of portions of Ruhi Institute Book 7 and the continued aid of an experienced tutor,

may further prepare the local friends for this task. As they serve

⁶⁵ in this manner and progress in their own study of the courses, their capacity to help others who desire to serve grows.

^{61.11} Where this approach is wisely applied, it sets a number

62 of people on the path of learning how to facilitate a process through which the
capacity of individuals eager to contribute to

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64 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONIntensifying the community-building process is raised.
Further,

65 by helping larger numbers of people to study institute courses,

it provides as early as possible a growing base of participation

by the local friends in the related activities. But a word of

caution is in order. The desired outcomes are less likely to occur

66 if the process of raising tutors becomes one in which everyone is asked to form a
study group the moment he or she finishes one

or two courses. In such instances, great effort may be expended

67 and large numbers briefly obtained, but the result sought of enabling ever more
people to promote the community-building

68 process remains elusive.

1.1 2 An expanding body of tutors

61.12 When the services of one or two visiting tutors are rein-

62 forced by a few local friends who are learning to offer institute courses, this team of
five or so individuals makes it possible

to expand the number of people studying the courses and

initiating activities, thus intensifying the work under way and

63 propelling the cluster on its path of progress to move beyond the second milestone.

61.13 Yet, the cluster requires an expanding body of tutors if it is

to continue to advance. If in each cluster the number of those

capable of serving as tutors is to rise, more people from among

those promoting teaching and community-building activities

have to keep advancing along the sequence of courses. For it is

only when ever-growing contingents are immersed in concur -

rent and sustained study and service that the body of effective

tutors meaningfully expands. This underscores the cumulative

62 character of the capacity-building process engendered by the sequence of courses.
With each course studied, knowledge

63 of the Faith increases, insights into spiritual matters deepen,

spiritual susceptibilities expand, requisite qualities and attitudes

develop, and skills and abilities sharpen. Individuals grow in

64 the ability to investigate the Sacred Writings, to understand the reality of their
community, and to engage in conversations

of significance. They become better able to consult on their

65 needs, to collaborate with others, and to reflect on and improve their efforts. As they
become ever more conscious of the divine

assistance surrounding them, they grow in confidence. When

such an experience embraces more and more people, and many

of them after studying Book 7 are assisted to form a study

circle and serve as tutors, they apply all these abilities in efforts

66 387

67 Supplementary Material to accompany others on the path of service. In this manner, a

cluster eventually comes to be served by a score or more local

friends capable of acting as tutors. Through their efforts the

number of individuals who are enabled to start and sustain core

68 activities and other acts of service in the cluster steadily grows.

1.1 3 Raising the effectiveness of those serving as tutors

61.14 In its Ridván 2010 message, the Universal House of

62 Justice observed that the worldwide Bahá'í community has "succeeded in developing
a culture which promotes a way of

thinking, studying, and acting, in which all consider themselves

as treading a common path of service," and has "acquired

63 the capacity to enable thousands, nay millions, to study the writings in small groups
with the explicit purpose of translating

the Bahá'í teachings into reality."

6 Within this lie the dynamics

7 of an irrepressible movement that can be fostered in local populations, and “much will fall on those who serve as tutors

in this respect.”

7 The House of Justice further explained:

61.15 Theirs will be the challenge to provide the environment that is envisioned in the institute courses, an environment

62 conducive to the spiritual empowerment of individuals,

who will come to see themselves as active agents of their

own learning, as protagonists of a constant effort to apply

63 knowledge to effect individual and collective transformation. Failing this, no matter how many study circles are

formed in a cluster, the force necessary to propel change

64 will not be generated.

65 8

61.16 Those responsible for overseeing the work of each institute

are charged with learning how tutors can become increasingly

effective in helping individuals release their potential to con-

62 tribute to progress within the clusters they serve. In this regard,

63 there are some specific concerns for each institute to address.

61.17 Friends who serve as tutors are most effective when they

62 understand well the institute’s purpose to raise human resources that are capable of fostering the process of community building

through the application of Bahá’í teachings. These friends

need to appreciate the nature of the institute process and “the

63 dynamics that underlie it—the spirit of fellowship it creates, the participatory approach it adopts, the depth of understanding it fosters, the acts of service it recommends, and, above all, its

reliance on the Word of God.”

9 They must become increasingly

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11 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONfamiliar with how the process enhances capabilities for serving

**the Cause by integrating study, practice, and service. As the
tutors gain experience, they acquire deeper insights into how**

each institute book builds on the previous ones to empower

12 individuals. They grasp the spiritual qualities each course elicits,

13 the attitudes it promotes, the knowledge it imparts, the skills it endows, the act of
service it introduces, and the interactions

14 it fosters.

61.18 Ultimately, tutors grow to be capable of facilitating the

62 study of the books in a way that enhances understanding and shapes attitudes, and of
organizing the practical components in

a manner that builds confidence. When tutors help participants

to begin applying, first in the context of the study circle and

63 then in the community, what they are learning, everyone—the tutors
included—appreciates better the nature of the unfolding

community-building process. Further, tutors promote a spiritu-

64 ally empowering environment and profound friendship among those studying
together. They link budding efforts of these

friends to the process of community building under way and

to the institutions and agencies of the Faith that stand ready to

65 support all those studying institute courses.

61.19 Of course, “the capabilities of a tutor develop progressively

62 as an individual enters the field of action and assists others in contributing to the aim
of the present series of global Plans.”

63 10

64 The coordinators of the training institute ensure that those acting as tutors are
properly supported by, among other means,

65 promoting mutual support and assistance among the tutors,

working alongside them in the field, and gathering them in

66 meetings for reflection.

Mutual support and assistance

61.20 Coordinators strive to create in a cluster an atmosphere in

which those serving as tutors—new and veteran alike—assist

one another in their service. Experienced tutors make them-

selves available to those taking their initial steps by either

offering together with them some of the courses or sharing with

⁶² them their insights. However, irrespective of the experience of the individuals involved, carrying out activities together in the

field and drawing on one another's knowledge serves not only

⁶³ to strengthen abilities but also to deepen commitment.

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Supplementary MaterialWorking alongside tutors and organizing

gatherings for reflection

^{61.21} Coordinators "bring both practical experience and dyna-

mism"11 to their efforts to work in the field with those serving

as tutors. The concrete questions that confront the tutors are

many. For instance, they seek to learn about the nature and

content of a conversation effective at inviting someone to study

⁶² Book 1, how to organize the first meeting of a study circle,

how to articulate well the aim of the sequence of courses and

⁶³ purpose of each book, and how to keep the discussion of the themes in the course focused and advancing. Many of these

questions are answered in the field as the tutors labor together

with others and are accompanied by a coordinator or a more

⁶⁴ experienced colleague.

^{61.22} Such interactions are complemented by regular gatherings

⁶² of tutors for reflection and for further study of the courses. In these occasions, tutors review relevant materials to deepen their

understanding of concepts underlying the institute process and

the Plans of the Faith, reflect on the efforts under way, articulate

⁶³ their evolving experience, and examine further the books they are offering. Depending on the number of tutors, these meetings

happen at different levels of the community—a village or neigh-

⁶⁴ borhood, a cluster or a number of adjoining clusters, and even a region or a country. Some gatherings involve all the tutors

and address matters of general interest; others focus on specific

groups, for instance, new tutors, those facilitating a specific

course, or those working with a segment of a population, such

⁶⁵ as youth or women. These occasions are most effective when the consultations of the friends are organized around a set of

⁶⁶ questions about which they are learning.

^{1.2} Ensuring a Steady Flow of Participants

through the Sequence of Courses

^{61.23} Capacity to sustain a steady flow of people through the

institute courses expands as the friends in a cluster learn to

engage increasing numbers in conversations on the teachings of

the Faith, nurture the participation of youth, manage a growing

stream of young people from junior youth groups into the main

⁶² sequence, and use in a complementary manner study circles and institute campaigns as modes of course delivery.

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FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION1.2.1 Fostering conversations on the

teachings of the Faith

^{61.24} The capacity to involve growing numbers in the study

of institute courses advances along with the ability to foster

increasingly rich conversations about the Bahá'í teachings

⁶² within a population. The sequence of courses itself lends some structure to how these conversations unfold. In its message

^{61.25} From the beginning of the sequence of courses, a partic-

ipant encounters Bahá'u'lláh's Revelation in considering

such weighty themes as worship, service to humanity, the

life of the soul, and the education of children and youth. As

a person cultivates the habit of study and deep reflection

62 upon the Creative Word, this process of transformation reveals itself in an ability to express one's understanding

of profound concepts and to explore spiritual reality in

63 conversations of significance. These capacities are visible not only in the elevated discussions that increasingly

characterize interactions within the community, but in the

ongoing conversations that reach well beyond—not least

between the Bahá'í youth and their peers—extending to

64 include parents whose daughters and sons are benefiting from the community's programs of education. Through

exchanges of this kind, consciousness of spiritual forces is

65 raised, apparent dichotomies yield to unexpected insights, a sense of unity and common calling is fortified, confidence

that a better world can be created is strengthened, and a

commitment to action becomes manifest. Such distinctive

conversations gradually attract ever-larger numbers to take

66 part in a range of community activities.

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61.26 The pattern and quality of the movement of people through

the sequence of courses greatly impacts how conversations on

the teachings advance in a population. The description that

62 follows, although generalized, will help to illustrate this point.

61.27 In a village or neighborhood where a small group begins

to study Book 1, the participants naturally converse on such

spiritual matters as the Word of God, prayer, and the life of

the soul. Praying, reading the writings, and bringing oneself to

62 account begin to take root among them as a daily discipline.

63 Possibility for exploring together other themes from the writings of the Faith grows when these friends are offered and

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⁶⁵ Supplementary Material begin reading the Hidden Words, as recommended in the first

unit of Book 1. The reach of this conversation expands when they initiate visits to the homes of their friends and neighbors to share prayers. The introduction of a few devotional meetings provides a space where more people, Bahá'í or not, gather to

⁶⁶ pray and reflect on the implications of the Writings for their individual and collective lives. This seemingly simple advance

becomes a means for inviting to the study of institute courses

⁶⁷ those who show receptivity, leading to an increase in people entering the path of service.

^{61.28} When some among those who have completed Book 1 come to study Book 2, the themes and concepts on which they deliberate with others broaden to include, for example, the eternal Covenant, unity in the community, Bahá'í principles relating to various social teachings, and others that arise as

⁶² the friends learn to respond to the needs of the hearer. The homes they visit in this connection become additional venues

for profound conversations. Bahá'u'lláh's teachings on the

⁶³ spiritual instruction of children—and on the part individuals, families, and the community play in this regard—begin to be

considered as some study Book 3 and a few children's classes are formed. Even a simple event convened with some regularity for families and neighbors to find out what the children are

⁶⁴ learning elevates discussion on the meaning and implication of a community nurturing its children spiritually.

^{61.29} When some people study Book 4, the conversations begin to touch more deeply on the Persons of Bahá'u'lláh and the Báb and on the interplay between crisis and victory that Their noble lives illustrate. The study of Book 5 fuels exchanges on

Bahá'í teachings relating to spiritually empowering the junior

⁶² youth, which, given the societal forces assailing this age group, resonate with youth, parents, and community leaders. The study

of Book 6 fosters the capacity to engage in “a conversation between two souls”

⁶³ 13—a direct teaching effort that “can become a

catalyst for an enduring process of spiritual transformation.”¹⁴

^{61.30} Thus, each course studied assists in enabling an expanding

number of friends to express their “understanding of profound

concepts and to explore spiritual reality in conversations of

significance.”¹⁵ In this way, a village or a neighborhood is

gradually suffused with discussions founded on the teachings of

the Faith and on the emerging experience in applying them to

creating a new pattern of collective life. With the range of possi-

⁶² 392

⁶³ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONble conversations, and “as experience grows, the friends become

⁶⁴ more adept at discerning when they have found a hearing ear,

at deciding when to be more direct in sharing the message, at

removing obstacles to understanding, and at helping seekers to

embrace the Cause.”¹⁶

^{61.31} The manner in which this capacity to engage a population

in conversations on the teachings is further systematized is

described in the following statement of the Universal House

⁶² of Justice:

^{61.32} As progress continues, the rising capacity for meaning-

⁶² ful conversation is harnessed in the plans of the institutions. By the time cycles of activity have formally emerged, this

capacity is being further stimulated through the expansion

phase that does so much to determine the outcome of each

63 cycle. The precise objectives of each expansion phase vary, of course, depending on conditions in the cluster and the

64 circumstances of the Bahá'í community. In some instances,

65 its main aim is to increase participation in the core activities; in others, readiness to enroll in the Faith is discovered.

Conversations about the Person of Bahá'u'lláh and the pur -

66 pose of His mission occur in a variety of settings, including firesides and visits to homes.

67 17

61.33 Besides portraying how the sequence of courses gives shape

62 to the unfolding of meaningful conversations on the teachings of the Faith in a population, what the description above seeks

to show is how the reach, depth, and coherence of these con-

versations, on the one hand, and the increase in the number of

63 people studying institute courses, on the other, fuel each other.

1.2 2 Learning to nurture the participation

of youth in institute courses

61.34 It is clear from the foregoing that much of the progress

of a cluster depends on the ability of the friends to engage a

population in diverse and weighty conversations on the Bahá'í

teachings and then to draw its members into an educational

process that multiplies their powers to contribute to the

62 building of a new society. It is natural, then, that at any point in this process the friends would encounter certain particularly

receptive segments of that population. As the House of Justice

63 has stated, the youth represent "a most responsive element of every receptive population to which the friends have sought

64 393

65 Supplementary Material to reach out."18 Initial endeavors to open a particular channel

for the entry of youth into the sequence of courses in a cluster

are necessarily modest. Effort is made—sometimes through

specially organized gatherings—to reach out to a group of

youth, engage them in discussions that open before their eyes “a

66 compelling vision of how they can contribute to building a new world,”

19 invite them to study the institute courses, and then

assist them to move swiftly into the arena of service. Often this

20 involves the intensive study of a set of courses such as Books 1,

21 3, and 5, since the acts of service to which they are first intro-

duced are usually teaching children’s classes and helping groups

22 of junior youth. As the process of growth advances, the manner in which the young people study institute courses gradually

comes to conform for the most part to the sequence in which

23 the courses are arranged. The institute might, however, from time to time offer some youth a selected number of courses in

24 order to accelerate the multiplication of activities.

1.2 3 A flow from junior youth groups

into the main sequence

61.35 Another channel opens up as more and more of those in

the junior youth groups turn 15 years old and are assisted to

begin studying institute courses. Early in the process of growth

a cluster may experience entry into the main sequence by a few

such young people. The first noticeable flow from the groups

62 might, however, occur only after the first three or so years of offering the program. Even then it might be quite modest.

Only when capacity to sustain large numbers of junior youth

63 in stable groups is present in a cluster does an appreciable flow happen.

61.36 To ensure the smooth transition of young people from the

groups into institute courses, the agencies gradually learn to

track the progression of cohorts of junior youth through the

texts; to help them see, as they near the completion of the

program or the age of 15, the prospects for further study and

62 service that await them; to organize formal events to welcome them as individuals or
as groups into the main sequence; and to

prepare the tutors, who, in some cases, may be the same friends

63 who accompanied them as animators, to work well with them. While the young
people “represent a vast reservoir of energy

and talent that can be devoted to the advancement of spiritual

and material civilization”

20 and they can do much to boost the

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22 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION efforts in a cluster, expectations of how fast they can
advance

need to remain reasonable. Rushing them through the sequence

for the sole purpose of increasing one activity or another might

in the long term prove counterproductive. It would be best for

them to advance along the sequence of courses at a natural

23 pace.

1.2 4 Progression along the sequence of courses

61.37 In its message dated 12 December 2011 to all National

62 following:

61.38 The main sequence of courses is organized so as to

62 set the individual, whether Bahá'í or not, on a path being defined by the
accumulating experience of the community

in its endeavor to open before humanity the vision of

63 Bahá'u'lláh's World Order. The very notion of a path is,

64 itself, indicative of the nature and purpose of the courses, for a path invites
participation, it beckons to new horizons,

it demands effort and movement, it accommodates different

65 paces and strides, it is structured and defined. A path can be experienced and known,
not only by one or two but by

66 scores upon scores; it belongs to the community.

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61.39 In this light, to raise more and more human resources in

62 each cluster, “an increasing number of friends are recruited to enter the first basic course, and relatively significant percentages

are then helped to reach higher and higher courses, acquiring

thereby the needed capabilities of service.”

22 If only a small

23 fraction of those who have studied the first course advance to the second one, and another small fraction of these friends

advance to the third course, and so on, the work of the institute

and ultimately the process of growth itself are robbed of the

24 required dynamism.

61.40 Progress of many people through the sequence of courses

is more likely to occur when the friends are able to associate

their studies to specific action. They are eager to study the

next course in the sequence when they understand that moving

together along a path of service enables them to contribute to

62 the advancement of their community. Such progress may be impeded when the courses are inadvertently presented as an end in themselves or as a mere deepening, when the pace of study

is too slow or too fast, when deliberations on concepts are not

63 395

64 Supplementary Material associated with experience, or when the practical components

65 of the courses are neglected.

61.41 To ensure that the number of those proceeding along the

sequence is substantial, institute coordinators, often with other

agencies in the cluster, meet periodically to review the flow of

62 participants from one book to the next. To determine when undue lag in the progression of many friends has occurred and

what its causes may be, they rely on accurate information about

63 participation in the courses. On the basis of a sound analysis, the institute may introduce measures—such as discussions with

the friends, well-timed institute campaigns, and the assistance

of visiting tutors—to remove obstacles standing in the way of

64 the continued participation of many people.

1.2 5 The delivery of institute courses

61.42 In most clusters worldwide, study circles remain the

62 predominant mode of delivering institute courses. In a cluster with a nascent program of growth, the first study circles are

usually formed by visiting tutors or a homefront pioneer. As the

number of local friends who can act as tutors grows, the capac-

63 ity to establish study circles necessarily increases. Apart from helping growing numbers to arise and serve, well-functioning

study circles foster among the friends and between them and

64 the institutions loving and mutually supportive interactions that bind these protagonists of the Plan together in unified action.

61.43 Study circles derive much of their effectiveness from the

fact that they each constitute a small group of friends who

study the courses together in a local setting with the explicit

purpose of learning to apply Bahá'í teachings to their personal

and collective lives and to thus contribute to a profound process

62 of change. In an environment marked by sincere friendship and common purpose, the members study the institute courses,

engage in service and extracurricular activities, and promote

63 this mode of learning to others. As more and more friends serve as tutors, various segments of a community's inhabi-

64 tants—youth, women, mothers, couples, young professionals,

and families—come to be accommodated in the study of the

courses and to play a part in efforts to promote spiritual and

65 material well-being. The study circles become distinct features of the life of the community when they operate with a measure

of formality, incorporating elements such as a formal beginning

66 and ending, a certain membership, and a defined schedule.

68 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONAlso, diverse and expanding numbers of the friends progress

along the sequence of courses when a degree of flexibility is allowed—the members, for instance, adjust as needed the pace at which they perform the various activities, and while some of them may leave when a particular course concludes, others

69 might join as the study of a new one commences. To ensure that the study of any particular course is not overly prolonged,

the friends might complement regular study with occasions for

70 intensive study that might last a weekend or a few days. When they have a healthy rhythm of progress, study circles do much

71 to invigorate programs of growth.

61.44 In order to accelerate the flow of large numbers of friends

62 along the sequence of courses, study circles usually operate alongside institute campaigns. In clusters where there is great

receptivity, campaigns might for a while even be the main mode

of course delivery. Involving the intensive study of two or more

63 institute courses over a relatively short time, institute campaigns are held at all levels of the community—local, cluster or group

of clusters, regional, or national. The institutions and friends

64 of the locality where the campaign is held are often involved in planning and providing resources, and the campaigns are most

effective when they are scheduled during times of the year when

many people can participate. A team of tutors— some perhaps

drawn from other communities or clusters—may be tasked

65 with implementing the campaign; these friends are required to give creative thought to carrying out the practical components

and accompanying the participants to initiate or extend their

66 acts of service. When offered in a locality, campaigns not only increase a community's human resources within a short period

but also raise local capacity to support institute activities and

invigorate the work of teaching and consolidation through the

67 practice and service activities of the participants.

61.45 For the agencies in a cluster, having a record of all study

62 circles and institute campaigns helps them to draw on the participants for the tasks of teaching, consolidation, and

community building. Occasionally, the agencies might gather

all those studying institute courses to reflect with them on

63 their studies and services, to nurture their commitment, and to help them integrate into the life of the community. As for the

training institute, its responsibility is to design, based on local

64 circumstances, an approach to course delivery that coherently combines study circles and institute campaigns so that capacity

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66 Supplementary Material to enable ever-larger numbers of people to progress along the

sequence of courses can continue to grow and become manifest

67 in an increasingly vibrant process of community building.

1.3 Coordination of the Main Sequence of Courses

61.46 The efficacy of the training institute depends largely on

there being at every point as a cluster advances an effective

arrangement for supporting the tutors, visiting or local. When

a program of growth is still nascent, support might come from

a hometown pioneer, a veteran tutor or a coordinator from

62 a nearby cluster, an Auxiliary Board member or an assistant,

63 or a regional or national coordinator. As more local friends begin serving as tutors, the most experienced among them

complement such external assistance by beginning to help oth-

ers. Often, after a cluster has passed the second milestone, the

number of local tutors begins to notably increase and a local

64 coordinator is named from among the tutors most willing to assist others in their services. In his or her efforts to accompany

the tutors, such a coordinator might continue to benefit, on the

65 one hand, from the support of a more experienced colleague from an advanced cluster or a regional or national coordinator,

and, on the other hand, from the assistance of capable local

tutors with whom he or she collaborates. In a cluster that has

passed the third milestone, in which the number of tutors grows

66 even larger, an additional coordinator or two for the main sequence may be named from among the collaborators. It is,

however, unreasonable to expect that, as a cluster progresses

67 further, “capacity would be built by simply assigning more and more coordinators”

23 to it. Strengthening mutual support and

assistance among the tutors guarantees that each of them is

24 always adequately supported.

61.47 Irrespective of the scope of the community-building process

62 in a cluster and the arrangements in place to support the tutors, the concerns that shape the endeavors of the coordinators are

mostly the same. In general, they ensure that the number of

those acting as tutors rises and capacity among them to offer

63 the full range of institute courses advances. They pay special attention to promoting the study of Book 7, help tutors to form

study circles, and aid them to learn to facilitate effectively the

64 study of the courses and the implementation of the practical components. New tutors especially require help inviting people

to study the institute courses and enabling the participants to

65 398

66 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION grasp the purpose and workings of a study circle. They often

also benefit from receiving assistance in facilitating the first few

sections of whatever course they are offering. Through such

support, the tutors come to appreciate that individuals persist in

their studies when they see themselves growing in understand-

67 ing, enhancing their capabilities for service, and engaging in spiritually enriching interactions. To help the tutors foster such

68 conditions in their study circles, coordinators, as stated earlier,

69 cultivate loving collaboration among the tutors, labor alongside them in the field, and gather them in meetings for reflection.

61.48 Depending on the circumstances on the ground, any one

of the coordinators of the three educational imperatives—the

main sequence of courses, the junior youth program, and the

program for spiritual education of children—might be named

first. Initially he or she might also follow the other activities

62 until other coordinators emerge. And when all are in place, they learn to complement one another and to periodically “examine

together the strength of the educational process as a whole.”

63 24

64 In collaborating with members of the Area Teaching Committee and with the Auxiliary Board members and their assistants,

coordinators—whether there is one or several—contribute to

assessing the progress of the community-building process and

65 ensuring that the activities in the cluster advance coherently. When, for instance, the Area Teaching Committee promotes

during each cycle a wide range of conversations on the teach-

66 ings, the number of people beginning to study the courses can be expected to rise. Equally, when the coordinator for the main

sequence keeps the Committee informed of all the study circles

and institute campaigns occurring, the Committee can draw on

67 the participants to advance the teaching work.

61.49 At the regional or national level, coordinators for the main

sequence of courses ensure that for each cluster there is an ar -

angement for supporting the tutors and that this arrangement

is not only effective but also adapts and expands in response

to growth. In this light, they ensure the timely appointment

62 of cluster coordinators. By working together with the cluster coordinators in the field and bringing them together in reflec-

tion meetings, they help these friends continue to grow in their

63 capacity to support the tutors. Appreciating the need for all coordinators at the cluster level to benefit from what is being

learned across the region or country, the coordinators organize

interactions among cluster coordinators that often involve visits

64 399

65 Supplementary Material to clusters where relevant experience is being generated. For a

small region or country, one coordinator may be sufficient. For

a larger one, two or more are needed over time and each may

be assigned to a part of the region or country. As is the case at

the cluster level, regional or national coordinators of the main

66 sequence also work closely with the coordinators for the junior youth program and the program for the spiritual education

of children while also collaborating with the Regional Bahá'í

67 Council, if one exists, and the Auxiliary Board members. Furthermore, they play a critical part in regional or national

68 consultative and planning processes.

2 THE JUNIOR YOUTH SPIRITUAL

EMPOWERMENT PROGRAM

61.50 When in its message dated 27 December 2005 the Universal

House of Justice urged all National Spiritual Assemblies to

“consider the junior youth groups formed through programs

implemented by their training institutes a fourth core activity

in its own right,”²⁵ further impetus was given to the expansion

62 of this vital educational imperative. The progress made since then has been impressive. Training institutes in almost all

national Bahá'í communities worldwide are now implement-

ing the program, albeit at varying levels of quantitative and

63 qualitative development. Globally, over 550,000 young people have already studied
at least the first text of the program. Those

64 currently engaged exceed 150,000 in more than 17,000 groups.

65 Thousands of youth, who find in the junior youth program “an ideal arena in which
to assist those younger than themselves to

withstand the corrosive forces that especially target them.”

66 26

67 are serving as animators of the groups, and hundreds of them as coordinators or
assistants to coordinators. Although the ex-

pansion has been more remarkable in some parts of the world

than in others, junior youth groups have generally found fertile

68 soil across a range of social realities—from small villages to the neighborhoods of
large metropolitan cities. More than 2,600

clusters with a program of growth have at least one junior

69 youth group, and some 70 have 30 or more groups, with 300 or more participants.

61.51 Notwithstanding the progress made, the capacity to offer

the program in cluster after cluster has to grow further. Two

broad realities are apparent in this regard: clusters where the

62 friends are striving to establish an intensive program of growth,

63 400

64 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION where the junior youth program may be in its early
stages;

and clusters where the friends are laboring to embrace large

numbers, where some basic capacity is present on which the

65 friends are building.

2.1 Clusters Where the Friends are Establishing

an Intensive Program of Growth

61.52 The knowledge garnered from efforts around the world

makes it possible to visualize with greater clarity the path of

progress of the junior youth program in a cluster. Institutes now

have to apply the available understanding in endeavors to firm -

⁶² ly establish junior youth groups in all clusters with a program of growth. Whether the initial efforts start with young people from Bahá'í families or those drawn from the wider community,

what needs to be achieved in such clusters may be conceived

⁶³ as helping the local friends develop the basic capacity required to establish the program on a sound foundation upon which

it can grow to edify hundreds of junior youth and invigorate

whole communities. This is no easy task. Numerically, it often

involves engaging and sustaining some 50 to 100 junior youth

⁶⁴ in about 5 to 10 groups, a capacity that is currently present in some 600 clusters worldwide.

^{61.53} Experience indicates that there are several dimensions

to the requisite capacity. Principally, there emerges in each

cluster a growing cadre of friends dedicated to the spiritual

empowerment of junior youth. The growth of the program is

greatly facilitated when these friends, however few they may

⁶² be, learn to read accurately the reality of their community and to identify local factors that might propel the program or

curtail its progress. The friends become increasingly capable

⁶³ of conversing with the community on the empowerment of the junior youth, a conversation that draws primarily on the

teachings of the Faith about this age group, most of which is

clearly articulated in Book 5 of the sequence of courses. This

conversation also provides opportunity to reflect on certain

⁶⁴ elements of the culture of the population that are conducive or contrary to the spiritual empowerment of young people.

Noteworthy too is engaging ever-growing numbers of youth in

⁶⁵ systematic conversations on "the contribution they can make to the improvement of their society"

²⁷ and on "providing for the

needs of others, particularly for younger generations."²⁸ Inviting

the youth to study institute courses is an essential aspect that

28 401

29 Supplementary Materialis fostered from the very start, and this is only possible when

capable tutors of Book 5, whether visiting or local, are available

30 to each cluster. The study of that course is most effective when,

in determining how to offer it, the conditions of the youth and

31 their experience are taken into account.

61.54 Once a few groups are formed, sustaining them depends on

how the animators are accompanied to learn to facilitate effec-

tively the study of the junior youth texts and to complement it

62 with artistic activities, social interaction, and service projects.

Pairing them with experienced animators when possible, gath-

ering them in periodic meetings to review the texts, enabling

63 them to learn from others more experienced, bringing them together in occasions to study the institute courses and the

junior youth texts have all proved to be effective ways in which

they can be supported. If animators are to grow in capacity to

not just help junior youth but also contribute in various ways to

64 bettering their communities, they gradually have to be assisted to appreciate the full extent of the community-building process

unfolding locally and the context within which the junior youth

65 program is unfolding.

61.55 Helping more and more youth to serve as animators

contributes both to an increase in the number of groups and to

the stability and resilience of the program. With more trained

animators, those that leave can be more easily replaced, and if

one animator is unable to facilitate the study of a particular

62 text, an experienced colleague steps in. When the junior youth in the groups functioning in a village or neighborhood, or even

in a cluster, are seen as enrolled into one educational system

⁶³ and their animators as collaborators in supporting all of them, occasions for coming together to study some of the texts in

camps or to implement service projects together become a more

⁶⁴ pronounced feature of the program in a cluster.

^{61.56} The program is strengthened when those overseeing it in a

cluster have explicit and reasonable expectations of what can be

accomplished over the course of a year. Currently nine texts are

available to the junior youth. While it is at present anticipated

that the junior youth will go through at least three texts in the

⁶² first year, establishing a rhythm of study that guarantees such progress sometimes proves difficult. This challenge is best met

when the way in which the program is implemented takes into

⁶³ account the circumstances of the young people—both junior youth and youth—in the community, the various activities in

⁶⁴ 402

⁶⁵ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION which they are engaged at school and at home, the general

pattern of life of their community, and the periods during the

year of intense and of relaxed activity. Such understanding sets

the stage for how in a cluster the junior youth will proceed

through the texts during a year—when, for instance, they will

⁶⁶ study at a regular pace in their groups and when they will all be brought together in camps for intensive study and service.

^{61.57} Yet another aspect of capacity to establish a sound and

steadily expanding program in a cluster is the involvement of

the parents and the entire community. The conversations that

occur as a group is formed and continue throughout its life

help to build unity of vision, thought, and action. Occasions

⁶² when the parents meet and the community gathers to reflect on the progress and efforts of the junior youth both extend this

⁶³ conversation and inject into the program the necessary vitality.

64 When they consult, the parents and the animators explore together the program's
underlying concepts, efforts to promote

65 junior youth groups in the community and with other families,

ways to acquire the essential materials, and means to mobilize

66 resources for camps and other collective endeavors.

61.58 As each cluster moves towards the second milestone and be-

62 yond, training institutes everywhere will focus on building the capacity to raise the
junior youth program to this basic level.

To assist them in this regard, the Office of Social and Economic

Development at the Bahá'í World Centre has captured the

63 knowledge and insights thus far generated in a document titled "Developing the
capacity to engage 50 to 100 participants in

the junior youth spiritual empowerment program." The remarks

64 above summarize some of the document's contents. It is hoped that it will be studied
by all the friends promoting the program

65 at the national, regional, and cluster levels.

2.2 Clusters Where the Friends are Learning

to Embrace Large Numbers

61.59 In all clusters where the capacity described above is present,

the friends are now striving to cultivate further the associated

interrelated abilities. They are enhancing capacity to engage at

least a few hundred junior youth in tens of groups, reaching in

62 this regard some 300 junior youth in about 30 or so groups.

63 One question before them in this connection is how to increase capacity to raise
growing numbers of animators in neighbor -

64 hoods and villages that are becoming centers of intense activity,

65 403

66 Supplementary Materialsome of which may be ripe for enlisting in the groups the
ma-

67 jority, if not all, of the local junior youth. Earlier in the cluster's

development, one or two tutors of Book 5 may have sufficed to

raise the initial cohort of animators. At this point, more of such

tutors are required if growing numbers of youth, and beyond

⁶⁸ them parents and members of local institutions, are to study the course. Attention to the quality of the junior youth groups also

becomes more pronounced. Animators are closely accompanied

⁶⁹ to learn how to consciously help the junior youth enhance the power of their expression, the acuity of their perception, and

the depth of their interaction. Ongoing and creative thought

is given to service projects initiated by the groups. By drawing

other members of the community into these projects, those

⁷⁰ initiatives showing great promise are sustained over longer periods. With such progress, the junior youth program attracts

the support of many of the local people and leaders who lend

⁷¹ a hand through several means. Additionally, opportunities to form junior youth groups in other settings such as schools and

community centers arise over time. In these various ways every

aspect of the learning experience in which the young people are

immersed comes to impact markedly their life and that of the

⁷² community in general.

^{61.60} Besides being accompanied in their service, youth serving as

animators are supported in other ways as well. In the context

of their service to the Faith and the community, they are, for

instance, encouraged in their formal education and assisted to

think about the prospects for tertiary training and for career de-

⁶² velopment before them. During reflection gatherings, animators deliberate also on such matters and on other noble aspirations.

In this they receive the aid of not only the institute coordinators

⁶³ but also other institutions and agencies of the Faith, such as Auxiliary Board members and Local Spiritual Assemblies.

^{61.61} In a community where the program has reached such a level

of quantitative and qualitative progress, rich conversations on

the moral and intellectual well-being of young people proliferate.

These conversations take place in the homes and during

62 occasions such as devotional gatherings, community meetings,

63 and institutional conferences. They also become a feature of the expansion phase of the cycle of activities. Gradually, the

program's fundamental concepts, aims, and objectives come

64 to be expressed through other means of communication; for instance, drama, music, or film. Where the program is operating

65 404

66 **FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION**At this level, large numbers of animators are sustaining their

efforts from year to year and progressively more youngsters are

67 continuing in the groups for the program's three-year duration.

A growing number of them are beginning to enter the main

68 sequence of courses and to offer acts of service.

61.62 As has been mentioned, there are about 70 clusters world-

wide where the program is reaching this level of development

and the friends are involving more than 300 junior youth in the

groups. In some of these clusters the number of participants even

exceeds 1,000. Achieving the progress described above in several

hundred more clusters where the friends are learning to embrace

62 large numbers is an important aspect of the current Plan. The part to be played by learning sites in this regard is critical, for

they ensure that the process of learning associated with each

further stage of the program's growth is effectively extended

63 and systematized in the clusters with which they are associated.

64 According to the capacity that exists, they collaborate with training institutes to carry the work to other advanced clusters.

2.3 **Coordination of Junior Youth Groups**

61.63 All of these efforts depend on there being at every point in

the program's advance a scheme for accompanying animators

that matches the need. As the groups multiply and become more established, the organizational scheme in place evolves in complexity. In the early stages, the support of an experienced

⁶² individual from a cluster close by may be adequate. This is soon supplemented by animators working in teams and the

assistance of the more experienced among them. Eventually

⁶³ one or more coordinators are named from among the local animators. As they take on their responsibilities they learn from

veteran coordinators in more advanced clusters and collaborate

closely with the cluster coordinator of the main sequence and

⁶⁴ of children's classes, if and when they are in place.

^{61,64} At the regional or national level, a coordinator is named

⁶² usually from among the most experienced cluster coordinators. As the number of junior youth groups increases across the

⁶³ region or country, an additional coordinator or two is named.

The regional or national coordinators work with the cluster

⁶⁴ coordinators in the field and bring them together in meetings of reflection. Capacity to support the program advances greatly

when a team emerges at the regional or national level composed

of the coordinators and other experienced individuals who, in

⁶⁵ 405

⁶⁶ Supplementary Materialcollaboration with the Auxiliary Board members, have a clear

vision of the growth of the program across the entire region or

country. As is the case at the cluster level, close collaboration

with the coordinators of the main sequence and the children's

education program is an important aspect of the mode of

⁶⁷ operation at the regional or national level.

^{61,65} Further, for capacity to grow, the institute and the learning

site, where one is in place, foster a dynamic collaboration. The

regional or national coordinators and the resource persons

work together in the field and, through such spaces as learning

62 site seminars and institute gatherings, learn from one another.

63 The knowledge and experience that emerge from the network of clusters associated with a learning site is transferred to the

training institute, and the insights generated by the training

64 institute in further extending the reach of the program is shared with the learning sites.

3 THE PROGRAM FOR THE SPIRITUAL

EDUCATION OF CHILDREN

the spiritual education of children has long been an element of

the culture of the Bahá'í community.”²⁹ Over the last Plan, the

4 number of children participating in the classes expanded significantly, reaching over 210,000 globally. The growing capacities

5 of institutes to train teachers and assist them to form classes,

and the expanding mechanisms to support their service and

6 progress, are among the factors that have contributed to such growth. Fundamentally, however, it is the mounting dedication

of individuals and institutions—indeed of the community as

7 a whole—to nurturing and empowering spiritually its young members that has provided the primary impetus. This is evident

in the fact that the number of children’s classes has increased

most in clusters where junior youth groups have also steadily

8 multiplied.

61.67 The current Plan’s objective of intensifying further the

62 community-building process in 5,000 clusters worldwide calls for marked development of the capacity to spiritually educate

children. Some of the particular demands in this regard relate to

clusters where the friends are striving to establish an intensive

63 program of growth. In most of these clusters, experience with children’s classes remains largely rudimentary. Other demands

are associated with those clusters where the friends are learning

64 406

65 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONto embrace large numbers, where most children's
classes are

66 currently found.

3.1 Clusters Where the Friends are Establishing

an Intensive Program of Growth

61.68 In clusters where the experience of the friends with
children's classes is in its initial stages, a principal need is
establishing a few classes by building organically on whatever
activities are present. From among those engaged in the core
activities and the conversations under way, a few who show
interest in teaching children are trained as teachers and assisted
62 to form the first two or three classes.

61.69 In each cluster with a few classes, a small team of teachers
is learning how to offer, lesson after lesson, the first grade, often
62 to children of varying ages. Much more is happening, however.

**A conversation on "the value of Bahá'í education and of a prop-
er spiritual upbringing"30 is being set in motion; the parents and**

63 teachers are establishing a collaborative relationship; and the classes themselves are
becoming a means to inspiring other peo-

64 ple in the community who are inclined to this area of service.

Further, a team of friends who over time might assume various

65 duties related to promoting children's classes is emerging from among the teachers,
the parents, and others.

61.70 As the classes grow in both quantity and quality, the insti-
tute strengthens its capacity to train ever-growing numbers of
teachers and to help them learn to teach grade after grade. A
basic organizational scheme is gradually built, and a pattern of
collaboration among the teachers, parents, and institutions is
62 progressively put in place.

3.1 1 Raising the first contingent of teachers

61.71 Initial efforts to increase the number of friends teaching children include raising tutors in a country or region who are capable of facilitating effectively the study of Book 3 of the sequence of courses. Initially, most of such individuals are drawn from among the experienced teachers and tutors in

62 the more advanced clusters. When they learn to offer Book 3 in a manner that raises the understanding of the participants,

enhances their commitment to the education of children, and

63 sharpens their skills and abilities, the spiritual education of children is established on a strong footing.

64 407

65 Supplementary Material 61.72 Although the first teachers in a cluster may come from any

segment of the population, young mothers and youth—both boys and girls—tend to be the first to respond. Mothers bring to the effort their experience of parenting and more readily engage other parents in related conversations. As for the youth, when

66 they are involved in deep discussions on their responsibility to the community, they respond especially well when invited to work with children and junior youth. Building a team of a few

mothers and youth who collaborate to teach the first few classes

67 should be a possibility within the reach of every cluster.

61.73 Regarding the training, it is, of course, envisioned that those

teaching children would need to have studied at least the first

three courses of the sequence. All the qualities and abilities

treated in these three courses, among them developing spiritual

identity and habits, engaging in systematic conversations, and

62 teaching a simple class of children, are relevant to a children's class teacher. Nevertheless, some flexibility in how individuals

proceed through these courses is often necessary in the early

63 stages. Friends interested in teaching children have sometimes studied the first and
third courses, formed classes, and then

**proceeded to study the second and other courses. In some
instances, forming children's classes is integrated into the study
of Book 3, so that by the time the teachers finish the course**

64 some classes have already begun. Whatever approach is initially adopted depends on
the experience and circumstances of the

65 people involved, and the support available.

3.1 2 Operation of the classes

61.74 At an early stage, the main issues pertaining to the oper -

62 ation of children's classes include helping the teachers learn to hold the classes with
increasing regularity, become adept

at handling the various components of the lessons in the first

63 grade, and strengthen relationships with parents. In this regard,

64 the teachers meet often to review the lessons, explore their principal spiritual
objectives, share experiences, and determine

how to assist one another. To continue to grow in capacity, the

65 teachers persist in their study of institute courses. As relevant experience accrues, the
teachers' commitment to spiritually

educating children strengthens, and so does that of the parents

and the community in general. This enables a community to

66 sustain the initial classes established.

67 408

68 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION61.75 The teachers' ability to collaborate with parents is
another

pertinent issue at this initial stage. Teachers learn to periodically

visit parents in their homes to acquaint them with the progress

69 being made and to elicit whatever assistance is necessary.

Efforts to enhance this vital relationship are seamlessly inte-

70 grated into the various activities associated with implementing the program. For
instance, teachers and parents study or review segments of Book 3 together, and parents
occasionally join the

teachers when they come together for reflection. The teachers

and parents are, as a result, increasingly engaged in a conver -

71 sation that nurtures among them a deep sense of solidarity. This conversation is gradually extended within the community, fostering friendship among the families and interactions in

various spaces, including devotional meetings, that serve to

72 attract the hearts of both children and parents to Bahá'u'lláh.

3.2 Clusters Where the Friends Are Learning

to Embrace Large Numbers

61.76 In advanced clusters, institutes are building on the capacities

so far developed in order to increase significantly the number of

children receiving spiritual education and to organize them in

a systematic program. The training of teachers is being further

augmented; the teachers are learning to offer the first three

62 grades and higher, as they become available; and the classes are becoming more formalized. Further, a pattern of coordination

is emerging through which steadily expanding numbers of

63 teachers in neighbourhoods and villages can be accompanied. The development of children's classes in these contexts is

64 contributing notably to the community-building process.

3.2 1 The training of teachers and progression

of children from grade to grade

61.77 Children's classes multiply significantly as the number of

people advancing through the sequence of courses grows and

some among them join the initial group of teachers in spiritu-

ally educating more and more children. This is especially the

case in clusters where the friends are able to engage growing

62 numbers of youth in meaningful conversations and assist them to study institute courses.

61.78 As the teachers learn to organize Grade 1 classes, they

62 continue to advance along the main sequence of courses. At the same time, they are
assisted to study the branch courses

63 409

64 Supplementary Material of Book 3 that prepare them to offer the subsequent grades

of the classes for which materials are currently available. The

qualities, skills, and abilities of the teachers sharpen further as

65 they are brought together periodically in reflection gatherings.

61.79 The experience acquired from teaching the classes week

62 after week and the understanding obtained from participating with others in
gatherings for reflection enable the teachers to

appreciate even further the special nature of the service they are

rendering. Their relationship with the parents of the children

63 grows stronger as they interact with them more regularly,

64 whether through home visits, special consultative meetings, or reflection gatherings.
In addition, their ability to contribute to

the community-building process under way advances mean-

ingfully when they play a part in various gatherings where

the community consults, reflects, and plans. All these factors

65 combine to strengthen the teachers' dedication to the program's objectives, sharpen
their vision of its development, and consoli-

66 date their resolve to sustain their efforts from year to year.

3.2 2 Further formalization of the classes

61.80 Growth in the number of children receiving spiritual educa-

62 tion necessitates more formalization of the classes. Organizing the children into
age-based classes, outlining an annual sched-

63 ule, and convening special events, such as children's festivals,

are among some elements of a formal system that receive due

64 attention. While previously the classes may have included children of different ages,
classes for distinct age groups are

65 formed as more teachers become available within the locality.

66 An annual calendar that is consistent with the pattern of life of the population is
established detailing when during a year the

classes generally commence, when they take a break, and when

they close, even as arrangements are made to accommodate new

classes forming at any time during the year. The calendar might

⁶⁷ also include dates for reflection gatherings of teachers and other cluster events that require the participation of teachers and

children. Certain formal meetings are held at particular points

⁶⁸ during the year involving teachers, children and their families, members of the institutions, and other interested individuals in

the community. What the children are accomplishing is shared

with those present, the efforts of both the children and teachers

are acknowledged, and as the children and teachers move from

one grade to the next, some recognition of this achievement

⁶⁹ 410

⁷⁰ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTION is made. Further, as the children advance through the classes,

⁷¹ those turning 12 are welcomed into the junior youth program.

3.3 Coordination of Children's Classes

^{61.81} During the early stages of the program's development,

⁶² teachers, however few they may be, learn to function as a team that meets regularly. The meetings of the team might

⁶³ initially be spearheaded by the most experienced among them.

Sometimes regional institutes have assigned to each cluster a

⁶⁴ veteran teacher or a coordinator from an advanced cluster,

⁶⁵ or the Auxiliary Board member might designate a capable assistant, to visit the teachers regularly and accompany them in

their efforts. Dedication mounts among the teachers when they

are enabled to interact with a larger body of their colleagues

⁶⁶ through gatherings hosted in more advanced clusters nearby.

^{61.82} As the number of teachers grows and their experience

⁶² deepens, one among them who has demonstrated capacity to help others is formally designated as coordinator. Such an

**individual might, of course, continue to receive assistance from
an experienced coordinator from another cluster as he or she**

63 assumes more formally the tasks of supporting others.

61.83 The continued multiplication of the classes in clusters in

which the friends are learning to embrace large numbers in

the community-building process places increasing demands

on the system of coordination. Here, the ability of teachers to

work in teams requires continued strengthening, as does the

62 ability of experienced teachers to help new teachers or those starting to teach a new grade. While one coordinator, perhaps

working with a small team of collaborators, can support 10 to

15 teachers, an additional coordinator is often required as the number of classes expands further. In any case, an organiza-

tional scheme emerges over time in an advanced cluster which

will accommodate teams of collaborating teachers; experienced

teachers that help the coordinators support others; and a num-

16 ber of coordinators that ensure the classes are being sustained, the teachers are growing in capacity, and the families and the

17 entire community are appropriately engaged.

61.84 At the regional or national level, the major concern is, of

62 course, ensuring that the friends in each cluster are supported so that, whatever the cluster's stage of development, children's

63 classes increase in both number and effectiveness. Raising tutors of Book 3 and ensuring that they are available to all clusters

64 411

65 Supplementary Materialis, as demonstrated, an indispensable aspect of the support

provided. Making certain that each cluster is served by some

organizational scheme, including drawing on coordinators

and experienced individuals from other clusters as needed, is

another. As coordinators emerge in cluster after cluster, those

66 serving at the regional or national level assist them in the field and bring them together in reflection gatherings that address

questions relevant to the stage of development of the children's

67 classes in their cluster. All materials in sufficient quantities and appropriate languages are provided to the teachers and

children at all ages. Careful attention to the flow of knowledge

from advanced clusters, where a greater range of experience is

being generated, makes it possible for other clusters to benefit

68 and advance expeditiously. And, as is the case with the main sequence of courses and the junior youth program, over time a

team emerges at the regional or national level composed of the

69 coordinators and other experienced individuals who, in collaboration with the Auxiliary Board members, grow in capacity to

70 follow the development of the program.

4 INSTITUTIONAL CAPACITY

61.85 The progress of each and all of the institute's programs

62 ultimately depends on the strength of the institute as an agency of the Faith operating at the level of a country or region. There

are currently over 300 training institutes worldwide, which

range in scope from those in small countries with a handful

63 of clusters with a program of growth to those in large regions where the number of such clusters might exceed 100. In all but

64 a few cases, these institutes operate under a board of directors.

65 Although in general all boards bear the same responsibilities, their particular operations vary depending on the range of the

66 institute's work. At any rate, it is vital that members of a board,

67 national or regional coordinators, Auxiliary Board members,

and a cadre of believers with the relevant experience learn

68 to collaborate effectively in supporting the institute's various responsibilities.

61.86 Irrespective of the scope of the work of the institute, the

board and those with whom it closely collaborates in a region

or country strive to enhance a number of related institutional

capacities. They endeavor to formulate a clear vision of the progress of the educational processes, foster capacity to learn systematically and to disseminate the accruing knowledge, and

62 412

63 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONsupport a healthy evolution of the institute's organizational

schemes at the cluster and regional levels. They also labor to

raise capable human resources for the institute's various pur -

64 poses, manage effectively financial and material resources, and address pertinent administrative concerns, especially in relation

65 to institute staff and statistics. The complexity of each of these issues naturally grows as the community-building process

66 advances in an increasing number of clusters across a region.

4.1 Formulating a Vision

61.87 Guidance to foster the growth of the Faith at its current

guidance, read the reality of their country or region, and reflect

on their experience, they are able to formulate a vision centered

62 on advancing the two essential movements at the heart of the process of growth: the steady flow of individuals through the

sequence of courses offered by the training institute and the

63 movement of clusters along a continuum of development. In the context of this general vision for the country or region, the

institute articulates its own particular vision for the spiritual

education of the friends for the duration of the Plan. This might

involve not only what is possible to accomplish in each cluster

64 with regard to the three educational imperatives but also the main strategies and approaches to be pursued. The institute

then formulates annually a plan and budget and every cycle an

65 operational plan. Where capacity for such methodical planning is well developed, the work of the institute is characterized by

clarity of thought and systematic action. Its lines of action are

well-defined, and the deliberations among the friends at the
66 **forefront of its operations are both practical and farsighted.**

4.2 **Learning and the Ability to Disseminate**

the Accruing Knowledge

61.88 **The members of the institute board collaborate with the co-**
ordinators, the Auxiliary Board members, and other experienced
individuals in “a systematic and concentrated effort ... to gather
and apply insights emerging from the grass roots regarding the
promotion of children’s classes, junior youth groups, and study
circles.”³¹ On their part, regional or national coordinators labor
in the field together with cluster coordinators, converse with
them on their experiences, and observe firsthand the emerging

62 413

63 **Supplementary Material** strengths and challenges. Regular reflection gatherings that
are

informed by what is happening at the grass roots allow for
a deep exploration of the unfolding experience in the region
or country. The deliberations and endeavors of coordinators
might for a period of time concentrate on particular sets of

64 **questions that are critical to achieving continued progress. The insights obtained**
from such focused efforts are then appro-

priately analyzed and shared with others. A cluster in which

65 **significant experience is gained may in this regard be used to host gatherings of**
coordinators from other clusters and dispatch

experienced individuals to other clusters to work with local
friends in the field. This is an approach to disseminating learning
that has worked well with learning sites for the junior youth

66 **spiritual empowerment program, and it is now being applied in some form in the**
context of groups of adjoining clusters that

are organized around one or more clusters which can offer “a

67 valuable source of knowledge and experience and represent a reservoir of human resources.”

32 Further, some institutes are also

capturing lessons learned by creating documents that serve as dynamic records of efforts to address a few key questions. With some of the knowledge generated globally about learning as a mode of operation now presented in Book 10, it is hoped that

33 the study of that course will help training institutes themselves achieve even more notable advances in this capacity.

4.3 The Evolution of Organizational Schemes

61.89 Those overseeing the work of the institute in a country or

region gradually grow in their understanding of how organizational schemes emerge and evolve as a cluster advances. The

62 overriding concern, of course, is ensuring that at every stage,

a cluster is served by an appropriate arrangement and that ca-

63 pacity for coordination keeps pace with growth in activity. This requires that there is at the regional or national level “an acute

awareness of circumstances on the ground,”

33 the basis upon

34 which decisions with regard to coordination are then made. In some clusters, an experienced person from another cluster

is assigned to assist the friends. In others, a few local friends

who are showing capacity to assist are accompanying those

35 who have initiated core activities. In still others, coordinators are formally named, while eventually, multiple coordinators

working in teams, each with a few collaborators, are raised. A

regular review of the organizational arrangements in clusters

36 414

37 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONand groups of clusters across the country or region, and of the

mechanisms in place to provide the necessary support, is an

essential aspect of the responsibilities borne at the national or

38 regional level.

61.90 Structures at the national or regional level evolve to attend

62 to these organizational needs of clusters. Periodic assessment should help those overseeing the institute's work to determine

in a timely manner when to reinforce or adjust whatever

arrangement is in place. When to name a regional or national

63 coordinator for each of the three educational activities; when,

64 as activity increases, to appoint additional ones from among those gaining experience in clusters; how to build teams of

friends at the regional level to help follow each program; when

to assign coordinators to work in parts of the region—are

all matters that are progressively addressed. The latter point

65 requires an additional comment. In large regions where regional coordinators are assigned to follow a number of clusters

or even groups of adjoining clusters, they are increasingly

66 operating at the level of a sub-region. As a consequence, a distinct administrative role at the regional level is emerging,

and, in some cases an individual is engaged to support the

coordinators operating at the sub-regional level by managing

funds, distributing materials, collating statistics, and organizing

67 reflection gatherings.

4.4 Enhancing the Capacity of the Institute Itself

61.91 As more and more clusters advance and the work of the

institute increases in complexity, well-defined measures are

introduced to help cluster and regional or national coordina-

tors to grow in capability, heightening their knowledge of the

Faith, their understanding of the Plan's overarching conceptual

62 framework, and their appreciation of the nature and purpose of the institute process. Their ability to explore the reality of

their region or country, to assess progress, and to plan effec-

63 tively can be enhanced, and certain practical abilities such as using statistical
information in reflection and planning and

64 managing judiciously the funds of the Faith can be developed.

Capacities such as building environments of cooperation and

unity are also cultivated. Some of these capacities are acquired

65 naturally through experience as coordinators are assisted to carry out their work.
Institutes identify other practical means

66 to help coordinators develop necessary abilities. For instance,

67 415

68 Supplementary Material individuals with relevant experience can help others; at
times

the institute can draw on other educational programs of the

69 Faith, such as those offered by Bahá'í-inspired agencies; and,

in some cases, coordinators and others serving the institute full

time have been supported to attend relevant training programs

70 offered by various institutions of learning.

61.92 In addition, an institute can benefit from the contributions

of other individuals with specialized skills who are involved in

the general community-building work of the Faith. Examples

of such skills include translating educational materials, man-

aging finances, and documenting learning. Through ongoing

62 assessment of the institute's evolving human resource needs and review of the
measures in place to raise the capacity of the

friends serving as staff or as volunteers, those overseeing the

63 institute's work determine ways of drawing on the friends with such abilities.

4.5 Managing Effectively the Financial

and Material Resources

61.93 Managing with care the financial resources pertains to all

aspects and levels of the institute's operations. When they are

planning and budgeting, the friends consider not only what

comes from the Funds of the Faith but also what the local

friends and community can offer through whatever means

62 available to them. On their part, institute boards, in collaboration with coordinators
and Auxiliary Board members, ensure

63 that each activity at the grass roots has the required resources.

64 In that light, effective channels for the flow of funds from the national or regional to
the cluster level are put in place, and

simple and straightforward arrangements for maintaining

accurate accounts are made. Awareness that the resources

of the friends and the funds of the Faith are precious and

65 not unlimited generates commitment to efficiency. Financial management itself is
approached with an attitude of learning,

and practices such as periodic budget monitoring and annual

66 financial reporting and auditing are established.

61.94 An effective system for the production and distribution of

institute materials is, of course, vital. Sometimes lack of such

a system has disrupted the progress of the three educational

imperatives and the vitality of the community-building process

itself. Careful thought is to be given to how the materials are

stored and how they are provided to each individual studying

62 416

63 FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONthe courses so that unnecessary waste does not occur.
Some

institutes utilize various approaches in this regard. They ensure

that cluster coordinators have access to basic storage space and

that when participants can afford to purchase the texts they are

64 encouraged to do so.

4.6 Some Administrative Aspects

4.6 1 Remuneration of institute staff

61.95 An important aspect of the management of financial

62 resources is the remuneration of institute staff. As the number of study circles, children's classes, and junior youth groups

expands in a country or region, more and more people deepen their sense of ownership and desire to contribute to the better - ment of society, and some among them dedicate a substantial amount of their time to the work of the institute. From among those serving as coordinators, some might require financial

63 assistance for a period of time. There are a number of principles to be considered by institutes in this regard. Of course,

capacity for coordination cannot be built by simply multiplying the number of coordinators serving full-time and receiving remuneration. At the cluster level, the remuneration offered to

64 some coordinators is essentially a short-term arrangement that is arrived at through conversation with each individual being

65 invited to serve in this manner and requiring such assistance.

66 Based on determined needs, factors that could be taken into consideration include "whether the person resides in a rural

67 or urban area, is required to change residence, has a family,

or intends to pursue further education."

34 While decisions

made will differ from one person to another, the system will

reflect an overall consistency. Additional considerations may

be necessary at the regional or national level. Some of the

35 friends serving full-time and receiving remuneration might,

36 for instance, need to continue receiving such assistance for an extended period in order to ensure that the learning processes

across the entire region or country are sustained. In any case, it

37 can be expected that whether at the cluster, regional, or national level, the needs of some individuals might sometimes "exceed

what can reasonably be met by the funds of the Faith."

35 A

³⁶ realistic range of remuneration can be established. In creating a framework for offering remuneration to the friends, a National

Spiritual Assembly, in consultation with the Counsellors and the

³⁷ 417

³⁸ Supplementary Materialinstitute board, determines what would, in general, constitute

a reasonable period during which an individual serving as a

cluster coordinator or as a regional or national coordinator

³⁹ may be provided with remuneration.

^{4.6} 2 Managing statistics

^{61.96} The availability of accurate and up-to-date statistical in-

formation helps the friends overseeing the work of the training

institute to “remain fully acquainted with developments at the

grass roots and what is being learned in the clusters whose

progress they oversee.”³⁶ The information is, of course, essential

⁶² in the institute’s planning and decision-making processes. A proper system for gathering and analyzing statistical informa-

tion requires that effective instruments are put in place for this

purpose, and the Statistical Report Program

(SRP) is helpful in

⁶³ this regard. A new version of this tool—combining its earlier versions and the Cluster Growth Profile—is already being used

in many regions and clusters. Ultimately, effective management

and use of statistics depends on close collaboration between

⁶⁴ cluster coordinators and Area Teaching Committees, as well as between national or regional coordinators and Regional Bahá’í

⁶⁵ Councils.

^{4.7} The Training Institute Board

^{61.97} As institutes advance as organizational structures, the

⁶² role of institute boards assumes ever-greater importance. The members of an institute board are appointed by the National

Spiritual Assembly or Regional Bahá'í Council, in consultation

with the Counsellors, usually for a term of two to three

⁶³ years. Through various means, including meetings and special occasions for consultation, boards watch over the work of the

institutes. They follow the unfoldment of the learning processes

⁶⁴ associated with study circles, children's classes, and junior youth groups, facilitate the formulation of vision, pay attention

to the administrative matters of institutes, and liaise closely

with the Counsellors and with National Assemblies or Regional

Councils, as the case may be. When they are composed of in-

⁶⁵ dividuals with the requisite experience and who are personally involved in the community-building process, and when they

are able to foster effective consultative relationships with

⁶⁶ others, appreciable progress can be made in a relatively short period of time. Although all do not function in the same way

⁶⁷ 418

⁶⁸ FRAMEWORK FOR ACTIONand the issues they face vary in complexity, growing demands

on institutes to continue attaining higher and higher levels

of functioning require that boards too become increasingly

⁶⁹ capable of carrying out their responsibilities.

[signed: International Teaching Centre]